

Welcome to the Crazy CAFE

by Alex Tabarrok December 5, 2025 at 7:17 am in **Current Affairs, Economics, Law, Political Science**

To let Americans buy smaller cars, Trump had to weaken fuel-efficiency standards. Does that sound crazy? Small cars, of course, have much higher fuel efficiency. Yet this is exactly how the Corporate Average Fuel Economy (CAFE) standards work.

Since 2011, fuel-economy targets scale with a vehicle's "footprint" (wheelbase $\times$ track width). Big vehicles get lenient targets; small vehicles face demanding ones. A microcar that gets 40 MPG might be judged against a target of 50-60 MPG, while a full-size truck doing 20 MPG can satisfy a 22 MPG requirement.. The small car is clearly more efficient, yet it fails the rule that the truck passes.



Photo Keith Hopper, <https://www.iobt.org/temple-blog/210-small-lessons-from-a-kei-truck-by-keith-hopper>

The policy was meant to be fair to producers of large vehicles, but it rewards bloat. Make a car bigger and compliance gets easier. Add crash standards built around heavier vehicles and it's obvious why the US market produces crossovers and trucks while smaller and much less expensive city-cars, familiar in Europe and Asia, never show up. At a press conference rolling back CAFE standards, Trump noted he'd seen small "kei" cars on his Asia trip—"very small, really cute"—and directed the Transportation Secretary to clear regulatory barriers so they could be built and sold in America.

Trump's rollback—cutting the projected 2031 fleet average from roughly 50.4 MPG to 34.5 MPG—relaxes the math enough that microcars could comply again. Only Kafka would appreciate a fuel-economy system that makes small fuel-efficient cars hard to sell and giant trucks easy. Yet the looser rules remove a barrier to greener vehicles while also handing a windfall to big truck makers. A little less Kafka, a little more Tullock.

Comments

Sort by Top

Hear hear!

2025-12-05 07:43:15

83

0

Hide Replies

#

Definitely a fan of this one.

It's hard to account for taste, but more choice is better. A truck that has a real bed that isn't shoulder high on the sides, and doesn't require some stupid step ladder for people to get into, and doesn't get anywhere near 6 figures to buy is a nice addition.

And don't even get me started on SUVs

JFA

2025-12-05 10:14:40

48

-2

Hide Replies

#

One thing that I wish were in the safety standards in the US: the effect on the other car. I think we'd see smaller cars, trucks, and SUVs if we accounted for the damage they cause in a crash.

corpore sano

2025-12-05 15:22:11

6

0

#

There are objective, very well studied, criteria for minimizing pedestrian impacts. They have to do with bumper height, hood slope and hood height. You could probably reduce one of the major sources of under 50 mortality overall by taking a sharp pencil to those geometry requirements for front ends.

It's all passenger cart/truck related. I've never seen a heavy truck kill a pedestrian, but unfortunately I've been witness to many private drivers causing near fatal and fatal accidents between car and pedestrians.

Jumfrey Tuckins, President of Texas

2025-12-05 09:37:09

English

#

↑ 16 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

People have been begging for smaller trucks for years. I say bring the El Camino back as well.

I'm curious of who will be using this the most. I drive a 1/2 ton, as i need to haul heavy things on trailers on occasion. I'll say this:I love being able to get into my truck and not kill my knees getting in and out like my wife's mid size suv. I'm tall and need not only the head space but room for my legs.

This truck reminds me of the old mail carts that were legal at 14 (still might be?). A friend had one and could drive to school before everyone else and the older kids would flip it over in the parking lot so we would help him flip it back at the end of the day. I suspect this is going to happen with these little trucks too.

Gilligan

#

2025-12-05 09:53:42

↑ 12 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

Personally, I'd like one of those \$12-15K BYD-style electric vehicles to take miles off my truck.

Jumfrey Tuckins, President of Texas

#

2025-12-05 10:32:18

↑ 3 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

I've been considering a used model 3 for the same reason.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 10:53:44

↑ 8 ↓ -8

Hide Replies

If your car decision doesn't end up on the Model 3, it's probably an emotional / irrational decision. (*)

At least if you don't have more than three kids or a job requiring a pickup.

I don't drive a Tesla, but I can admit I'm making an emotional decision in so doing.

(*) This isn't exactly the best thing you can say about Tesla, given the role of emotion in car buying.

Sure

#

2025-12-05 11:43:54

↑ 7 ↓ -2

Hide Replies

Ehh, a PHEV gets you maybe 90% of the benefits of full EV setup but also allows you to not have to worry about trips into the great beyond, arctic cold (e.g. driving to Edmonton), or the rest.

And I suspect that the Model Y is more rational for a lot of folks than a Model 3. Performance is basically the same but having more cargo space for travel, kids, pets, or even just a Home Depot run is worth the very slight premium for the price.

When buying a car (at least as the only vehicle you have) I would say that you want to weight both the most common (e.g. commuting) use and the most finicky drive of the year you do (e.g. vacation, driving home for the holidays with the kids, picking up spring lawn supplies in bulk).

If FSD ever gets regulatory approval to let the driver sleep, that will make it worth it for a lot of people to buy whatever allows that option.

Continue this thread →

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 11:06:55

↑ 5 ↓ -2

Hide Replies

"North Dakota in the winter."

Sure. There are undoubtedly a few hundred thousand people who have that set of circumstances.

They're still very popular in Canada, though, which is the North Dakota problem turned to 11, so maybe it's not that bad.

Continue this thread →

Shayne

#

2025-12-05 11:01:48

↑ 4 ↓ -3

Hide Replies

Or you live in an area where you have to drive long distances in extreme cold. Lithium battery technology is not meant for cold places like North Dakota in the winter.

[Continue this thread →](#)

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 12:29:53

↑ 2 ↓ -1

"But it's a great reason why mandates, especially federal mandates, are unjust. Ditto for soft-mandates i.e., subsidies."

Yeah, for sure.

The Model 3 is the best car if you are considering a Honda Accord, Toyota Camry, or similar. Not if you are considering an F-250.

Gilligan

#

2025-12-05 11:44:17

↑ 1 ↓ -1

>Sure. There are undoubtedly a few hundred thousand people who have that set of circumstances.

But it's a great reason why mandates, especially federal mandates, are unjust. Ditto for soft-mandates i.e., subsidies.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 12:31:34

↑ 0 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

"And I suspect that the Model Y is more rational for a lot of folks than a Model 3."

I wasn't really distinguishing between the two. You can substitute "Model Y" for "Model 3" in my statements and they are equally true.

Hybrids, though, carry around two complete powertrains. That's a solution driven by regulation, and it won't persist.

[Continue this thread](#) →

Wayfaring Stranger

#

2025-12-06 05:57:28

↑ 1 ↓ -1

"If your car decision doesn't end up on the Model 3..."

WTH? Corolla and \$17K cash for the win. It's called "math".

Wayfaring Stranger

#

2025-12-06 15:42:51

↑ 0 ↓ 0

"The Model 3 is the best car at being a car. "

AFAIK, there's no such thing as the "best" this or the "best" that. There is only "best product *for the money*". I doubt that fits any Tesla, unless part of your calculation is the status it brings you.

As for utility, EVs aren't there yet. My Honda can do 1000 miles in 12.5 hr gas stops and all. Even under the most ideal conditions, the M3 would cost at least 90min additional in charge time.

Would you drive your M3 on dirt? I've driven my Honda up logging roads.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-06 16:00:31

↑ 0 ↓ 0

"Would you drive your M3 on dirt? I've driven my Honda up logging roads."

That is a big advantage of driving a piece of junk. You don't care what happens to it.

But assuming you mean Model 3 and not actually M3, I don't own a Model 3. I don't own an electric vehicle of any sort.

My point is that for most people, the Model 3 is the best combination of features and price for their needs. If you really need to tow and off road, a Ford F Series of one sort or another is almost certainly better for you. And despite the fact that the Model 3 is cheap to buy and very

cheap to own, there are people who can't afford it.

For me, the Model 3 can't carry my family; I need more seats in at least one vehicle. And I'm old fashioned and emotional and personally want to drive something that feels better, at least in another vehicle.

But if you're comparison shopping Accords and Camrys and the like, and statistically most people are, the choice is obvious. Serious professional truck needs, big family, too poor, driving afficianado who thinks \$100k is a reasonable price, okay maybe there are better choices for you. But for most people, most of the time, it's the sweet spot.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-06 14:29:31

↑ 2 ↓ -3

"WTH? Corolla and \$17K cash for the win. It's called "math"."

The Model 3 is the best car at being a car. It's the best combination of qualities at a reasonable price.

There are cheaper cars, but you begin to sacrifice important features.

There are more expensive cars, but you are paying a lot for modest gains.

Preferences are heterogenous and we all have our own budgets, so please make your own choice.

Also, as I alluded to, the Model 3 is kinda dull, so there's that. Of course the Corolla is a soulless Japanese econobox which scores even worse in any emotional assessment.

Crikey

#

2025-12-05 21:03:15

↑ 0 ↓ 0

The cheapest BYD EV in Australia is ~US\$14,200 before tax. There's no tariffs on them, but it does cost money to get them up to rich country safety standards & ship them over. But the US has an advantage in that China drives on the same side of the road. EVs will continue to improve and fall in price. As over half of Australian households will have free electricity available in the middle of the day, if they want it, in July, outside of niche cases, there's no point in buying a new ICE vehicle. It will take some time for people to realise that, but I expect the fall in conventional vehicle sales to be pretty brutal here. It has already started.

Clay

#

2025-12-05 10:41:04

↑ 9 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

Urban deliveries come to mind. Basically anything that involves narrow roads and other cramped spaces. Also, assuming they're inexpensive a lot of general hauling jobs that people use pickups for now.

Taiwan, for instance has tons of these and they're ubiquitous for just about everything and handle the tight urban streets as well as twisty mountain roads. People use them in cities to carry and set up their food stands and make all sorts of deliveries. People use them in the country for fruit and brush and building materials and brush and whatnot.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 10:46:18

↑ 5 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

"Also, assuming they're inexpensive a lot of general hauling jobs that people use pickups for now."

There is a whole market of side-by-sides and other off-road vehicles that addresses this now. It's not on-road, but then, on-road you generally don't have the constraint of narrowness and cramped spaces. Maybe in Europe, but not really in the U.S., even in the older cities.

Jumfrey Tuckins, President of Texas

#

2025-12-05 11:04:01

↑ 1 ↓ -1

Hide Replies

From the manual transmission, to the model 3, and to the side-by-side... i couldnt agree more with everything you've mentioned. We are in total alignment here.

Also, Lord Action is a fantastic name. Well done.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 11:09:23

↑ 1 ↓ 0

Thank you! Merry Christmas!

Harun

#

2025-12-05 12:20:38

↑ 0 ↓ 0

I hitched a ride to a factory in Taiwan in our printing factories tiny blue truck. Its so small it could not go on the main highway - too slow, so we had to take back roads.

Trip was about 50% longer than via highway, IIRC. Also the seating is hard on your bones. But it was fun.

Engineer

#

2025-12-05 12:02:24

↑ 9 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

I was driving routinely at 15. At 16, I got a pick-up, because it was cheap. Manual transmission, crank windows, bench seat, heater, AM radio. Very happy to have it. My younger sister got it when I left for college.

There's a market for low cost, simple low amenity vehicles, but I can see why the car companies are not enthusiastic. Many of the same issues that builders run into with low cost houses.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 12:39:47

↑ 1 ↓ 0

My second car was a similar beater small pickup. My first car was an ancient large sedan.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 10:44:28

↑ 4 ↓ -2

Hide Replies

"People have been begging for smaller trucks for years. I say bring the El Camino back as well."

I'm all for diversity in the market. Regulation shouldn't make this hard.

But I worry a bit about it being car enthusiast talk not backed by markets. Do we really think Ford, GM, Dodge, Toyota, and Nissan are all making their trucks bigger because they're stupid? Or do they think that's what sells?

It's like manual transmissions. YouTube is full of influencers railing against car makers for not offering manuals. Which they don't offer because, though they're interesting to aficionados, they aren't really practical for a lot of people and consequently they don't sell.

"I'm curious of who will be using this the most. I drive a 1/2 ton, as i need to haul heavy things on trailers on occasion. I'll say this:I love being able to get into my truck and not kill my knees getting in and out like my wife's mid size suv. I'm tall and need not only the head space but room for my legs."

I suspect smaller vehicles make a lot more sense in an urban country where the average adult male is 5'7".

Gilligan

#

2025-12-05 10:53:30

↑ 6 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

If the floor on vehicles is \$50-60K, then I need it to handle just about every use case (i.e., it more-or-less needs to be a pickup truck or SUV). If they are \$10K, I'd be willing to buy a 1 or 2 seater that I just use for in town errands.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 10:55:50

↑ 2 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

They are \$50k because of the collision of NHTSA and CAFE. It's very hard to be sufficiently safe and to meet fuel economy standards at the same time because the best engineering solution to the first is to make the car heavier and the best engineering solution to the second is to make the car lighter. So the consequence is that we need to make the car expensive to be both safe and efficient..

Gilligan

#

2025-12-05 11:50:08

↑ 4 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

I'd be happy with a 45 mph cap and a 60 mile limit. Basically, the all-weather version of an e-bike.

Slightly off topic: I'm pretty sure a such an e-car would be safer than an e-bike...by virtue of having 4 wheels if nothing else. What's the relevant comparison here?

[Continue this thread →](#)

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 12:38:20

↑ 2 ↓ -1

"Slightly off topic: I'm pretty sure a such an e-car would be safer than an e-bike...by virtue of having 4 wheels if nothing else. What's the relevant comparison here?"

I would think so. E-bikes strike me as frighteningly unsafe, though part of that is based on my strong desire not to run over a child even if it's the child's fault.

mikeInThe716

#

2025-12-05 11:15:23

↑ 1 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

The near death of the manual transmission is related to safety-ism. Manuals must be crash tested independent of automatics.

Manuals also have some CAFE *costs* because they are not optimized like today's complex automatic transmissions.

Manuals still exist in higher end models. The market is making enthusiasts pay. And maybe manuals make a comeback? CAFE's Regulators and Enforcers are now knee-capped via the BBB.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 12:36:55

↑ 1 ↓ -2

"The near death of the manual transmission is related to safety-ism."

Meh, it's related to traffic. That's what's kept me from buying a manual, despite driving around in one of the few cars available with a well regarded manual option.

"Manuals also have some CAFE costs because they are not optimized like today's complex automatic transmissions."

Oddly, manual gear ratios seem designed to make you accelerate to 60 slower than the paddle shifter for some sort of brand engineering reason. Often the gearing is really tall, so much so that you don't do a lot of shifting in speeds that are legal on public roads.

There's nothing inherent about only having six gears that requires you not to enter third gear before 90 mph.

Mandelbaum, Mandelbaum

#

2025-12-05 21:58:06

↑ 0 ↓ 0

I think they are making them bigger (and fancier) for the same reason houses are getting bigger - that's what maximizes profits.

Horhe

#

2025-12-08 16:47:37

↑ 0 ↓ 0

Where I am from, automatic gearboxes are rare and they cost extra (around 1500 euros depending on car model). I barely see one, despite the streets being full of new cars. Culture?

Slocum

#

2025-12-05 10:55:11

↑ 1 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

"People have been begging for smaller trucks for years."

And they got them in the form of the Ford Maverick and Hyundai Santa Cruz.

Moses Taylor

#

2025-12-05 11:47:23

↑ 4 ↓ -1

Hide Replies

The Santa Cruz is barely a pickup truck. I don't know, that's more like the retarded love child of an El Camino and a Pontiac Aztek.

Slocum

#

2025-12-05 12:13:43

↑ 2 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

People now value back seats more than a large bed, and that's true in pickup trucks of every size.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 12:41:30

↑ 3 ↓ 0

It's nice to be able to throw hockey equipment or potting soil in the bed and sit a family in the cab. Most families are not lugging around drywall often, but bicycles or other sports equipment gets driven around multiple times a week.

Gilligan

#

2025-12-05 13:57:22

↑ 2 ↓ 0

Supercabs are pretty nice. Full back seat + a separate area for smelly, gross stuff.

Pepé Silvia

#

2025-12-05 11:44:14

↑ 8 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

Wouldn't higher fuel taxes be preferable to these bizarro mandates about fuel efficiency?

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 12:42:45

↑ 2 ↓ 0

Yes, probably. If you agree with the goal, that would be a better way of achieving the goal.

Though you might find people the elasticity to be less than you'd like.

Mike Arden

#

2025-12-05 09:30:05

↑ 12 ↓ -9

Hide Replies

From ChatGPT5.1

Short answer: no. The CAFE tweak makes kei-sized vehicles less penalized on fuel-economy math, but there are still big federal safety/emissions and state registration barriers that this rule doesn't touch.

To sell new kei trucks in the U.S. (not just 25-year-old imports), you still have to clear:

a) Federal Motor Vehicle Safety Standards (FMVSS)

Any new motor vehicle sold here has to comply with all applicable FMVSS: crashworthiness, airbags, lighting, etc. [OBJ]

Most Japanese-market kei trucks do not meet those standards as built; they were never designed for them. That's why:

- New kei trucks are not sold in the U.S.
- When they show up, they're usually:
- 25+ years old and imported under the "antique" exemption, or
- Sold/registered as off-road/utility vehicles, not normal on-road cars.

Industry explainer: "New kei trucks are not sold in the United States because they do not meet Federal Motor Vehicle Safety Standards (FMVSS) or comply with EPA emissions standards." [OBJ]

For Trump's "let's bring in the cute kei trucks" promise to really bite, NHTSA would have to either:

- Create a new vehicle category with weaker standards (politically hard; safety pushback), or
- Automakers would have to design U.S.-spec kei-style trucks that fully meet FMVSS—likely heavier, more expensive, and a bit larger.

A Road & Track piece pretty bluntly calls his kei-plan a "regulatory nightmare" for exactly this reason: FMVSS would need rewriting or special exemptions. [OBJ]

b) EPA emissions rules

Separately, new vehicles must meet EPA emissions standards. Non-conforming vehicles either have to be:

- Modified/tested/certified by a specialized importer, or
- Old enough to qualify for exemptions (21+ for EPA, 25+ for DOT). [OBJ]

That's why 25-year-old kei trucks are already importable today (under the normal "25-year rule"), and the CAFE tweak doesn't really change that part of the landscape.

So CAFE change ≠ "EPA and FMVSS magically satisfied."

3. State-level road legality: still a mess

Even if you clear federal hurdles, you run into 50 different state DMVs:

- Some states allow 25+ year-old kei/mini trucks on certain roads (often ≤ 35 mph) and treat them like low-speed vehicles or farm equipment. [OBJ]
- Other states either ban registration outright or are actively tightening the rules (e.g., Michigan, Georgia; RI's 2024 bill limiting new registrations while grandfathering existing owners). [OBJ]
- There are fresh 2025 maps/articles still showing a patchwork of which states let you register kei trucks, and where, and at what speeds. [OBJ]

None of that is changed by a federal CAFE interpretation. States can still say: "We won't title/register these as regular road vehicles."

Clay

#

2025-12-05 09:35:30

↑ 21 ↓ 0

Even if it doesn't make the pictured vehicle legal, it's still a step in the right direction.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 10:33:31

↑ 4 ↓ 0

"The CAFE tweak makes kei-sized vehicles less penalized on fuel-economy math, but there are still big federal safety/emissions and state registration barriers that this rule doesn't touch."

Yes. American vehicles are the way that they are because of the collision of CAFE with vehicle safety regulations (NHTSA et al). Fixing CAFE, while good, does not solve the whole problem.

The conflict with markets and preferences comes about because (1) people want safety in the vehicles, and (2) it makes no sense to care about the fuel economy of an average vehicle where fuel costs are dwarfed by other costs over the life of the vehicle. So we've set up a bunch of rules to require both safety and economy, which pushes vehicles to expensive high-tech.

Absent the full set of rules, vehicles would be on average nicer, bigger, safer, but less easy on gas. So we regulate them to be twice as expensive and not as nice, but they're reasonably safe and reasonably economic. And in the process we have all sorts of unintended side effects.

Randall

#

2025-12-05 10:23:20

↑ 1 ↓ -1

Sounds like a great opportunity to design and build a crashworthy American variant of the cute little buggers. I'll be in line for one.

Kailer

#

2025-12-08 12:53:54

↑ 0 ↓ 0

Yup. New rules still retain the original sin of giving smaller vehicles tougher rules. And safety and other rules lock in status quo. It's all just little old lady who swallowed the fly after that. At least they're ditching those engine shutoff at stop gimmicks.

It Ain't Necessarily So

#

2025-12-05 09:07:30

↑ 28 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

Now that the Nissan Versa has been discontinued, beginning in 2026 there will not be a single new sub-compact car available for sale in the US. This is nuts.

Slocum

#

2025-12-05 10:58:58

↑ 3 ↓ -8

Why? Manufacturers discontinued them because they weren't popular enough. They're less useful (and less safe) while saving relatively little in either purchase price or fuel -- and the ability to better fit in small parking spaces is really not much of a concern in most of the US.

MikeP

#

2025-12-05 08:19:10

↑ 28 ↓ -4

Hide Replies

There's a coming repair of a similar Kafkaesque environmental law in California around grocery bags.

I am of course against idiotic plastic bag bans. But the prior law banning "single-use" plastic grocery bags allowed grocery stores to sell at a state-set price either paper bags or *super thick plastic bags*:

(b) (1) In addition to the requirements in subdivision (a), a reusable grocery bag made from plastic film shall meet all of the following requirements:

...

(E) It shall be capable of carrying 22 pounds over a distance of 175 feet for a minimum of 125 uses and be at least 2.25 mils thick, measured according to the American Society of Testing and Materials (ASTM) Standard D6988-13.

The Kafkaesque twist here is that the old "single-use" plastic bags are good for dozens of uses. Carry lunch. Carry things to the beach. When they start to wear out, line a trash can with them. Critically, they are very light and take up almost no space when they are empty. They have zero carrying cost when unused.

The new 2.25 mils thick plastic bags, however, are heavy and are enormous when empty. They are bulky and terrible and are not useful for having around. I authentically and truly use them only once because they are so painful to carry empty, while single-use plastic bags I use many many times because they are so wildly convenient to carry empty.

Fortunately single-use bags can still be had taking out from restaurants so I have bags to use to take lunch to work and bring back empty from work.

Moral Panic

2025-12-05 10:30:48

↑ 8 ↓ -4

Hide Replies

My local county in Maryland will ban plastic bags at checkout starting January 1. Cannot even sell them, only paper. Exceptions for carry out and pharmacy. Feels so outdated, but there always must be a cause to pursue.

This year gas leaf blowers were also banned. Yeah, electric one are quieter. Gotta love however the pickup I saw this week with a loud generator cranking in the bed charging blowers while the workers were off with others.

MikeP

2025-12-05 11:42:48

↑ 2 ↓ -5

I'm in the Bay Area, so our city banned gas leaf blowers in 1991. But it wasn't until a couple months ago that we got a nastygram from the city that someone had reported our gardener was using one.

I of course was willing to escalate and let the gardener keep going as he was, but when we talked with him he was okay converting to electric, though at a price because he needed to purchase one.

Now that these letters have gone around, I'm hearing a lot more electric leaf blowers in the neighborhood. I'll just say that I prefer the sound of louder but lower gas leaf blowers to the quieter but higher pitched whine of electric leaf blowers.

And it's not just because the sound of a gas leaf blower is the sound of freedom: the higher pitched whine of an electric leaf blower is also annoying.

mkt42

#

2025-12-05 12:23:45

↑ 1 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

How are you carrying those empty bags around? I simply drive around with several in my car, and grab one when I go into a store (supermarkets in Portland charge 5 cents if you fail to bring your own bag). I have a random panoply of sturdy plastic bags and cloth bags (very thick, compared to plastic) that were usually giveaways at some event or another or that I bought to support some non-profit organization.

If I wanted to carry one in my knapsack, which I sometimes do, they're annoyingly bulky. But I get a trickle of the thinner single-use plastic bags, even in anti-plastic Portland, so I've got a supply of those too.

However the take-out places and non-supermarkets that give out those single-use plastic bags are gradually using thinner and thinner ones that have less durability and strength. If they become too prevalent I'll still save and re-use them -- but I'll use two of them to have a double-thick bag.

MikeP

#

2025-12-05 15:43:00

↑ 0 ↓ -1

Hide Replies

How are you carrying those empty bags around?

In my Reason Magazine tote bag of course.

 English

In the morning I carry full lunch containers in the plastic bag separately from the tote bag holding my laptop satchel, power cords, and thermos of coffee. In the evening the empty containers go back into the plastic bag, which goes into the tote bag.

At home I remove the lunch containers and leave the plastic bag in the tote bag. And days when I don't take lunch to work the plastic bag remains in the tote bag.

The difference in volume and stiffness between a thin "single-use" plastic bag and a 2.25-mil "125-use" plastic bag is a factor of 20 or 30. It's simply painful to have the thick plastic bag fighting for space with the power cords.

The notion that the thick plastic bag that is much less useful but consumes an order of magnitude more resources was an environmental improvement is comical. It is amusing that it was called a "loophole" for the plastic bag industry. It's not a loophole: It was the damn spec in the damn stupid legislation -- stupid at its core by interfering with the relationship between the store and the customer and stupid in its implementation by working directly against its objectives.

MikeP

#

2025-12-05 16:54:51

↑ 0 ↓ 0

...stupid in its implementation by working directly against its objectives.

It's almost as though the legislators support these things only for the signaling and aren't very good at writing legislation or imagining it in practice.

Engineer

#

2025-12-05 07:35:45

↑ 29 ↓ -6

Looks considerably easier to park as well.

It's a good example of pragmatic Trump vs. ideological mandate progressives.

Good to have a choice. I know a guy who commutes between Houston and Dallas every few weeks in a comfortable F-150, and needs car seats. The smaller pickup wouldn't work for him.

dbp

#

2025-12-05 09:39:12

↑ 24 ↓ -2

We should eliminate CAFE entirely. Government micro-management makes us all poorer.

dman

#

2025-12-05 09:31:03

↑ 21 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

I'm generally for this.

But, as a small car driver, driving one has gotten terrible over the past few years due to:

1) Every car is huge and it's pretty annoying that you can't see over/around them. The size/height of cars also does not seem to have made its way to where the 'no parking' signs go in front of intersections (more difficult than it should be to see cross traffic when going through an intersection).

2) The super bright LED headlights from taller cars really blind you in the small cars. I now drive with my driver-side mirror angled all the way out and all the way up...not ideal but it's better than being blinded every time i look into.

Wish he did this in his first term!

John Mansfield

#

2025-12-05 10:22:59

↑ 13 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

It is bizarre that low beams that blind drivers of on-coming standard sedans are allowed to be manufactured and imported. I wonder how blinding headlights are overlooked in the many safety regulations that control the cars we can buy.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 10:50:34

↑ 2 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

Ha!

It's partially a consequence of technologies like smart-dimming, which dim the parts of your beam that would be pointed at other drivers dynamically, are banned! The technology is active and the regulations are conservative, etc, etc.

 English

mikeInThe716

#

2025-12-05 11:26:17

↑ 3 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

I may be wrong, but a quick search showed that such self-dimming headlights are *allowed* in the US. They are just not *mandated* by Kommissars Types that infest the EU.

Note that while self-dimming headlights are neat, *repairing and properly adjusting them* is likely to be a low-four figure expen\$e...

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 12:44:21

↑ 0 ↓ 0

That may have changed and I'm out of date. For a while, we weren't allowed the Euro spec ones with the dimming feature.

Thanks!

Hi

#

2025-12-05 07:48:17

↑ 14 ↓ -1

I assume the picture shows the two trucks have the same bed size? Interesting. Yes, I like this move.
Thanks Trump

chuck

#

2025-12-05 10:29:52

↑ 12 ↓ 0

"The policy was meant to be fair to producers of large vehicles"

Economists getting high on their own supply.

The policy is intended to **advantage** producers of large vehicles, beyond their native ability to compete in an open market. "Fairness" is specifically being avoided here. Generally using government action to solidify a firms market position and protect it from competitors is considered rent seeking, a concept economists sometimes pretend to oppose but is in fact a termal goal for most firms in a capitalist system.

J

#

2025-12-05 11:17:36

↑ 4 ↓ -1

One might even imagine that, in the absence of regulation, the price of fuel itself would incentivize less use...

Mitchell

#

2025-12-05 12:20:16

↑ 3 ↓ 0

I hope that relaxing the standards will allow for compact and medium-sized sedans (with a trunk) to have the ground clearance of a lot of small SUV's. So, they would get say 35 mpg hwy instead of 40 mpg hwy - due to more air going under the car. BUT for about 20 years now a sedan is so low to the ground that it could scoop up road kill and carry it around and don't get me started on what a pain it is to change the oil yourself without ramps.

John Mansfield

#

2025-12-05 10:39:57

↑ 1 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

The car I wish I could buy:

Three rows of benches that each seat three adults comfortably. Each row would have its own pair of doors, so six doors. No center console in the front blocking a third front seat there. Not a mini-van with a back row meant only for kids. Shorter length and narrower width than a full-size 12-passenger van.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 10:59:41

↑ 2 ↓ 0

The Ford Excursion came close to this. No third-row doors, though.

People loved them, and they last forever. You still see them on the road. But this is a small market.

As a large family guy, I have similar needs. I made do with a minivan, but it has a lot of shortcomings, particularly as the boys get older and bigger.

Gus smithe

#

2025-12-05 11:10:42

1 0

Hide Replies

There are a lot of factors that caused Americans to only buy big trucks and SUVs. The emission standards are one piece of the story. It's gotten so bad that many brands are cutting sedans entirely and becoming only SUV. Volvo did this. I believe Ford and a few other others are now pure SUV or have maybe one or two sedan models as an afterthought or for foreign markets. It's really dumb. Most of those SUV buyers are driving them to target and have no actual off-road plans.

Slocum

#

2025-12-05 12:11:06

6 0

Hide Replies

"There are a lot of factors that caused Americans to only buy big trucks and SUVs. "

But they don't. Some of the top-selling vehicles in the US are fuel-efficient compact crossovers like the Toyota RAV4 and Honda CRV. Calling them 'SUVs' because of their tall-wagon shape doesn't make them into hulking behemoths. They're perfectly reasonable vehicles for runs to Target.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 12:46:29

3 0

Hide Replies

Agreed. I don't know that the most popular vehicles would be that small absent regulation, but we aren't talking Suburbans here.

People really do seem to want a higher roof, a bigger and more accessible cargo area, and optional 4wd.

Slocum

#

2025-12-05 14:44:13

1 0

"People really do seem to want a higher roof, a bigger and more accessible cargo area, and optional 4wd."

Exactly. And not only in the US -- these kinds of 'tall wagon' vehicles have become much more popular around the world (including in Europe).

Bob

2025-12-05 12:29:16

↑ 2 ↓ -1

Hide Replies

CAFE has been a big boon for gender affirming vehicles: One of the most woke policies known to man.

Gilligan

2025-12-05 16:12:43

↑ 4 ↓ 0

>Subaru Outback has entered the chat

Jim

2025-12-05 17:22:08

↑ 1 ↓ 0

This is a good point from Alex T. I would just point out that those trashing CAFE, Alex would most likely propose something you might hate even more to lower emissions.

Marc

2025-12-05 16:05:05

↑ 0 ↓ 0

The footprint-based CAFE distortion is real: small cars face tougher targets than large ones, and the rule embeds a clear bloat subsidy. But I think the conclusion—that CAFE makes microcars “hard to sell”—overstates its causal role.

CAFE is a *fleet-average* system, and automakers optimize across the portfolio. Small cars often function as compliance assets, sold at low margins precisely because they help offset trucks. A kei car that “fails” its own footprint target can still raise a manufacturer’s overall average.

The real constraint on microcars isn’t regulatory—it’s demand and margin structure. U.S. consumers overwhelmingly buy SUVs and crossovers, and those vehicles generate far higher profits. Even with looser CAFE, kei cars won’t appear without Japan-style policy inducements, because there’s no meaningful U.S. demand for them.

So while the footprint rule is indeed a Tullockian distortion, relaxing it mainly benefits truck makers. Microcars aren’t missing because they can’t comply; they’re missing because Americans don’t want them and automakers can’t profitably sell them.

Rich Berger

#

2025-12-05 07:48:47

↑ 8 ↓ -9

Hide Replies

Per Wikipedia:

CAFE standards are administered by the secretary of transportation via the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration. The original CAFE standards sought to drive automotive innovation to curtail fuel consumption, and now the aim is also to create domestic jobs and cut global warming.[3][4] Stringent CAFE standards together with government incentives for fuel efficient vehicles in the United States should accelerate the demand for electric vehicles.[5]

So now that fossil fuel is plentiful and the case that fossil fuels will cause catastrophic warming has fallen apart, why have CAFE standards?

dearieme

#

2025-12-05 08:10:28

↑ 16 ↓ -13

But what about the incomes of all the people who make their living from environmental scares and doltish bureaucracies?

Women and children worst affected.

Bluto

2025-12-05 08:56:05

#

↑ 1 ↓ -5

Hide Replies

Dnc, I'm still getting a Wagoneer this year

Lord Action

2025-12-05 11:03:40

#

↑ 2 ↓ 0

You'll spend a lot of time getting it repaired.

rayward

2025-12-05 10:51:39

#

↑ 4 ↓ -11

Hide Replies

Real men drive trucks. The bigger the manlier. Okay, real men with large payloads need large trucks. But as we know, lots of small men (dentists, lawyers, insurance salesmen, doctors, college professors) drive large trucks to make up for their small payloads.

dearieme

2025-12-05 17:47:51

#

↑ 0 ↓ 0

My first driving experience was on a tractor, so ya boo to effeminate "trucks".

James Harris

2025-12-05 08:53:08

#

↑ 8 ↓ -20

Hide Replies

Nonsense. The old standards acknowledged that some people needed to buy trucks (including business owners) and that others had legit need for small cars. They aren't substitutes for each other. If someone was going to buy a truck, make it a more fuel efficient truck. Ditto for small cars. It was a way to improve fuel efficiency within the constraint of legitimate non-fuel needs.

 English

Gilligan

#

2025-12-05 09:57:19

↑ 20 ↓ 0

Hide Replies

The trouble is that CAFE is a "corporate average" standard. It basically forces auto companies to offer a full line of vehicles....which in turn, made it hard for new entrants.

Lord Action

#

2025-12-05 11:05:05

↑ 6 ↓ 0

This is the best, most "economics", comment on here.

This is also the reason why established carmakers aren't that bothered by rules like these. It's part of their moat.

Comments for this post are closed